sense of renewed solidity, she adds. "It will have a ripple effect in some 100 assembly seats in the state, from west to east where the Yadavs are dominant."

BJP'S CASTE MOBILISATION

Karhal is also where the BJP is trying to score one over the SP president. But taking Akhilesh on in the SP's strongest bastion is no easy task. After much brainstorming, the party has zeroed in on Union MoS for law and justice S.P. Singh Baghel, who they feel could upend the caste equation. Padma Tripathi says, "Karhal is dominated by Yadav voters, but it also has about 35,000 Shakya votes, and some 30,000 each of Baghel and Thakur votes. The Shakya and Thakurs are the core vote bank of the BJP. Their strategy is to polarise non-Yadav votes."

Baghel, a former sub-inspector and PSO of Mulayam, was a three-time SP MP from Jalesar in Etah. After a tiff with Mulayam, he moved to the BSP, then the BJP. He has never won against any member of the Yadav family, but feels confident of his chances are good this time. "The elite castes along with the non-Yadav OBCs are with the BJP, making our challenge very strong," says Baghel. The BJP has fielded non-Yadavs who were once close to Mulayam in other a seats as well, like Om Prakash Nishad in Shikohabad (Firozabad district), and Ashu Diwakar in the Kishni reserved seat of Mainpuri. But SP leader and Saifai block chief Santosh Shakya is unfazed: "The BJP did not have candidates for many seats here, which is why they have nominated leaders of other parties. It's a sign that they are worried."

BATTLE FOR SHAKYA VOTES

An interesting battle is on for the Shakya votes in the SP stronghold areas. Alok Singh Shakya, an Etawah resident and president of the 'All India Shakya Mahasabha', says, "The Shakyas, Mauryas, Kushwahas and Sainis in UP are backward castes with a similar agrarian social structure. Every assembly seat in these eight districts has 12-15 per cent Shakya votes. Parties have been mobilising our voters to counter the political influence of the Yadavs." In 2017, the BJP had fielded Shakya candidates in four seats here, including Karhal. They won in Amritpur, Bidhuna and Patiali. To appease the Shakya community, the BJP had sent Geeta Shakya, former district president of the party in Auraiya district, to the Rajya Sabha in November 2020. Almost a year later, in September 2021, she was made president of the state Mahila Morcha.

But it may not be enough. Amatesh Shakya, principal of a private college in Auraiya, says, "In 2017, the BJP had projected then state president Keshav Prasad Maurya as the CM candidate, which is why the Shakya vote went en masse to the party. There is resentment at the way he was sidelined in the Yogi government." Senior leader Swami Prasad Maurya, who left the BJP for the SP recently, has been lambasting his former party over the neglect of the Maurya, Shakya and Kushwaha castes at every meeting in Mainpuri and Auraiya. The BJP has deployed deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya to counter this narrative. Local strongman Raghuraj Shakya, a two-time MP from Etawah, has also been roped in to bolster the cause.

There is also the question of development. Before 2017, Akhilesh's government had started work on two major projects in the region, a trauma centre in Bewar area of Mainpuri and a sewage system in Saifai. Both have been in limbo since the Yogi Adityanath government came to power and the BJP is finding it difficult to justify the lack of action. Former Badaun MP and Akhilesh's cousin Dharmendra Yadav says, "The Yogi government has discriminated on development in Etawah, Mainpuri and adjoining districts in the past five years. It's a big issue this election."

THE MULAYAM FAMILY RIFT

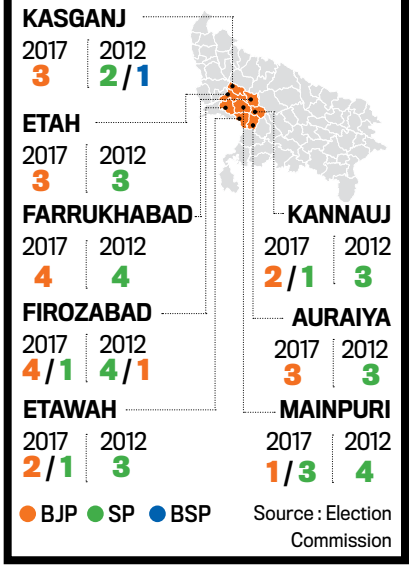
The Mulayam family's internal troubles have been a gold mine for the BJP. His rebellious daughter-in-law Aparna Yadav, recalcitrant brother Shivpal Yadav, SP founding member Hari Om Yadav, the BJP has played up every little rift among them. It has also managed to poach Aparna and fielded Hari Om as its candidate from Sirsaganj in Firozabad district. A two-time MLA from the seat, he fell out with the family last year after supporting the BJP candidate for the Firozabad district panchayat president's post.

A plus for the SP is the truce with Shivpal. After falling out with Akhilesh, Mulayam's younger brother had formed the Pragatisheel Samajwadi Party (Lohia) in 2018 and damaged the SP in the 2019 Lok Sabha election. Shivpal is contesting from the Jaswant Nagar seat in Etawah as an SP candidate this time. On January 31, as soon as Akhilesh filed his nomination from Karhal, he congratulated him on social media. Shivpal says the ill will is a thing of the past. "The public will give a befitting reply to the BJP's efforts to break our bond. The Yadav family is one in seeking a win for the SP." ■

IN THE YADAV DOMINION

- There are **28 ASSEMBLY SEATS** in the 'Yadav belt'. This dominant OBC group makes up over 20% of the voters in every seat
- Over 20% of the voters are Muslims in 22 of these seats. The **M-Y VOTERS ARE OVER 40%** in 20 assembly seats
- There are **SIX RESERVED SEATS**, the SP won just 2 while the BJP took 4 in 2017
- In 2012, 10 **YADAV CASTE CANDIDATES** of the SP won the elections here. In 2017, only four such candidates won

BJP'S RISE IN SP STRONGHOLD



Graphic by ASIT ROY